thing for the player as well. It drives you mad sometimes: you feel almost like he knows you better than you know yourself. He knows that playing soccer is what I'm all about and decided, I think, that me captaining the team that night would help the other lads and, at the same time, give me a break from the chaos of the previous few days away from Old Trafford. Once I'm out on the field, nothing's ever got in the way of me doing my job. The manager knew it wouldn't that night either, and I got the first goal, from the penalty spot, in a 2–0 win.

I got a break in that game, too, but not the kind I needed. A few minutes before the end, I went in for a challenge with their center-forward, Trevor Benjamin, who's a big lad, and he fell on top of me. I was left sitting there knowing something serious had happened: I could hardly breathe. Afterwards and over the next few days, the United medical staff said I'd just bruised my ribs. I trained. I even played at the weekend. They thought that, if there'd been a fracture, I'd not have been able to do either. I was convinced the pain meant there was more to this than bruising though and, when we followed it up, the scan showed I had actually broken a rib.

I've never had trouble with injury beyond little niggles but this was my second in less than a year: This particular knock was maybe a blessing in disguise. I never want to miss games, but even before the season started I'd been feeling tired, mentally and physically, after coming back from Japan and, now, I didn't have any choice but to rest. I joined up with England for a get-together during the international week. The whole squad was invited to Buckingham Palace, which was something I couldn't miss out on. I felt unbelievably proud, being introduced to Her Majesty the Queen again as the England captain. She asked about my injury—last season's foot, I think she meant, not this season's rib—and about our arrangements since the kidnap plot. She obviously took an interest in that, personal security being something she knows all about herself.

For what seemed like the first time in ages, we took the boys on vacation, just us for a week in Barbados. Arranging it was a bit stressful: where to go, who to tell about it and the rest. We decided at the very last minute and just told the family but, by the time we got to the hotel, the papers had tracked us down. Who knows how it happens? Someone on the plane, or at the airport, sees you and passes the word along? It meant we spent almost the whole time by the pool, which was fenced off and private. The very last day I took Brooklyn to the beach, which was only a few yards away from our villa, and the cameras were already out there, waiting. I know I'm lucky to be able to fly off to a beautiful place in the sun and enjoy the luxury; not so lucky,